frankly pathetic batting display. John Wright, our coach, was livid and took it out on a few plastic bottles in the dressing room.

The poor performance hurt even more because it followed the high of the first ever Indian hat-trick in Test cricket. Harbhajan had picked up Ponting, Gilchrist and Warne in succession on the first day, swinging the match in our favour again after Australia had reached a position of strength at 252–4. Bhajji was brilliant throughout the series and this was the very best I had ever seen him bowl. First he had Ponting lbw, then he followed up with the wicket of Adam Gilchrist. Understandably there was a lot of talk among the players before the hat-trick ball and I had an urge to tell Bhajji what I thought he should bowl to Warne, the new batsman. However, I decided not to and all I said was that he should bowl what he thought best. He ended up bowling a low full toss, which Warne played into the hands of forward short leg.

At the end of our first innings on the third morning at Eden Gardens, even though we failed to avoid the follow-on, there were signs of better things for us when Laxman, batting at six, managed to add a few runs with the tail. He scored 59 and was the last man out. There was a brief discussion in the dressing room and we all agreed that Laxman, who was obviously in good touch, should go in at three for the second innings, with Rahul moving to six. None of us had any idea that this swap would result in history being written.

Laxman and Rahul batted like champions in the second innings and I thoroughly enjoyed seeing an extraordinary batting effort unfold before my eyes. India scored 335 runs in the second innings on day four without losing a single wicket. Not to lose a wicket in a day is unbelievable and to do it against the world’s best team makes the achievement all the more miraculous. Laxman played some unbelievable shots off Warne and both he and Rahul had to battle serious physical exhaustion in the intense heat and humidity, but they held on, eventually scoring 281 and 180 respectively, and by the end of the day we knew we couldn’t lose the Test match. In fact, we had started to believe that we had a slim chance of winning if we bowled well on the last day. This in itself was a dramatic turnaround, because for the first time in the series we had managed to put Australia under pressure, just as I’d hoped.

We declared early on day five with a lead of 383 and knew we had a chance if we could force the Australians back with a few quick wickets. Harbhajan was bowling with exceptional skill, but we needed someone